

Alejandro Velazquez

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Product design leader with 20+ years building and scaling fintech, open banking, payments, SaaS and platform products across Europe and Latin America. Founding designer at Yapily, where I built the design function and now lead a team of two, owning product design across the platform.

Experienced partnering with executive leadership, product and engineering teams to deliver customer-centred solutions in highly regulated environments. Specialised in API-first platforms, developer experience, payment infrastructure and enterprise SaaS.

EXPERIENCE

Lead Product Designer & Design Manager — Founding Designer

Yapily — London — open banking infrastructure across the UK and Europe

Jan 2020 - Present

- Joined as the company's first designer and built the design function. Now manage a team of two product designers, owning hiring, onboarding and performance reviews; seven designers managed across six years as the team changed shape.
- Led the strategy, design and launch of Hosted Pages, the white-label bank-connection and consent flow spanning over 2,000 banks across 19 countries, reducing customer integration effort from four to six months — sometimes over a year for complex cases — to around two weeks. Now used by 200 companies, including Google, Adyen, Intuit, Ant Financial and Revolut.
- End-to-end conversion rose from around 20% at the 2023 beta to 65-75% today, varying by use case and market — moved incrementally over three years by UX, frontend and backend together, alongside expanding bank coverage. A meaningful share of that is infrastructure and I don't claim it as a design result.
- Where design was the lever: time to find a bank fell from 5-15 seconds to 1-3 in most markets and 3-5 in branch-heavy ones, through display names matched to what people call their bank, search alias gaps found in testing and passed to engineering, and the grouping and shortcut redesign of bank selection. Embedded login conversion improved by roughly 13% and the decoupled handoff by roughly 10% where it was retained — both directional, from overlapping production experiments.
- Built the research practice with no dedicated research function: over 200 customer interviews at a sustained monthly cadence since 2020, a 2023-2026 programme of moderated and unmoderated end-user testing across usability, market coverage and live bank integrations, with real people connecting real accounts, commissioned usability, accessibility and competitor benchmarking studies through Testbirds and Applause, and guerrilla testing for early iterations. Set up a bi-weekly feedback forum and shared prioritisation board with product, customer success, support and engineering, and restructured the documentation information architecture through card sorting, testing findability before and after.
- Defined the experimentation pipeline with product and built it in-house with engineering, enabling live A/B testing against production traffic. Screen-level results include improved conversion on bank selection, and reduced drop-off and user error on the QR code handoff.
- Led the accessibility work on Hosted Pages. A commissioned external audit identified approximately 94 changes across code, contrast and focus behaviour — including contrast failures and screen readers announcing raw SVG markup because alternative text was implemented incorrectly, leaving the flow unnavigable by screen reader. We postponed a release to fix both rather than ship and correct later, and I documented the findings for the frontend team to work from. A separate unmoderated study of 21 testers in Germany, including participants with disabilities, found 62% preferred the redesigned flow, rising to 78% among testers with disabilities.
- Mapped the end-to-end customer journey across sales, customer success, technical services, support and operations, and led the information architecture for the Console redesign that followed. Ran a two-day hackathon with engineering, product and implementation, role-playing as an outside consultancy using only what a real customer can access, to surface onboarding blockers. The Console is in beta; the Hosted Pages configurator shipped in full, giving customers self-serve control over every screen — previously a support ticket and an engineer per request.
- Wrote Yapily's open banking UX guidance for customers building their own experiences — covering end-to-end flows, consent screens, consent dashboards, return experiences, re-consent journeys and checkouts — delivered as documentation plus interactive demos.
- Set the vision and problem framing for demo.yapily.com, led its design and maintain it with my team — an indexed library of live demo journeys running real end-to-end flows against mock and live banks, used in implementation, sales and RFI conversations.
- Built three design systems from scratch for different consumers — internal tools, the white-label customer-facing foundation, and the marketing site — documented in Storybook and Figma on a shared three-tier token layer, with around 38 engineers and 4 designers building against them. Built the contribution and approval governance jointly with the frontend lead, and handed each established system to a designer on the team.
- Led design across six rebrands and the yapily.com homepage redesign with marketing and two external agencies, and lead the team producing brand and sales collateral behind go-to-market.
- Partnered with executive leadership on product strategy, prioritisation and platform vision, and supported the compliance team on FCA presentations.
- Worked with designers and product managers at Google over two years as they built open banking products on Yapily. Currently leading migration of the design systems into AI tooling as part of a company-wide AI transformation.

Lead Product Designer

HeadBox — London — enterprise event technology and SaaS platform

Dec 2018 - Dec 2019

- Led product design through a leadership transition with no reliable way to measure product performance. Three rounds of research with 45 customers and non-customers, alongside observation, support and message analysis, refocused the team on the enquiry-to-booking funnel, where only 20% of enquiries received a host proposal. Much of the host research was done on site, in venues from local pubs to Kensington Palace and the O2.
- Shipped the Enquiry Hub as a deliberately small experiment — London only, capped at £10k — which showed the platform connected hosts and guests well but converted poorly, and led to the pivot from marketplace to SaaS lead generation.
- Tested the lead feed with a spreadsheet before anything was built: recent enquiries, filtered, shown to twenty venues. Eighteen of the twenty became confirmed bookings.
- Designed and launched the company's first SaaS product for venue partners, generating £150,228 ARR from 117 customers within three months — four times the prior model's performance, with more than 1,500 leads in the first month.
- Established the design system, governance framework and research practice used across the organisation.

Product Design Lead — Co-founder	
Su4erheroes — London — product design consultancy	Nov 2016 - Dec 2018
Co-founded a product design consultancy with former Payfriendz colleagues; company director from January 2018. Led design across all client and internal work.	
Docomo Digital — principal client — global payments and commerce infrastructure	
- Led design on NOMO, a payout platform built so marketplaces could hold third-party money without becoming a licensed payment institution — a licence costing upwards of €200,000 and taking up to 18 months. Four surfaces for four audiences: an internal admin console for onboarding partners and their compliance documents, a dashboard for marketplace owners, a mobile app for the sellers being paid, and API documentation. - Designed payment, payout and reconciliation experiences for international marketplaces and sharing-economy platforms, simplifying workflows involving settlements, merchant management and international payments. Collaborated with product, service design and engineering teams across Europe and Asia. - Also delivered a cashback app for Huawei customers.	
Caremoni / My Support Broker — 2017-2018 — personal health budget payments, with the NHS	
- Designed a payment and reconciliation platform for a social enterprise managing NHS personal health budgets, where allocation, payment and reconciliation were entirely manual and error-prone. - Interviewed every party in the chain — operators, independent carers, care agencies and people receiving care — then ran a concierge pilot with a plain front end and payments still processed by hand, which corrected a wrong assumption about digital confidence and reframed the problem as admin burden. - Designed an operator dashboard for budget allocation, spend monitoring and NHS reporting, plus an app for carers and customers to request and authorise payments, designed to remove the manual work from reconciliation and NHS returns. The product reached MVP and ran as a pilot with a subset of customers.	
Lead Product Designer	
Payfriendz — London — digital wallet and peer-to-peer payments platform	Oct 2013 - Nov 2016
- Directed mobile and web experience design across multiple product releases with two designers and fifteen engineers, working closely with founders to define product strategy and platform evolution. Built the UI component system and mentored support staff into research roles. - Designed user journeys supporting digital wallets, peer-to-peer payments and emerging embedded finance capabilities, and introduced user research and usability testing practices that informed prioritisation. - Result: £5M+ transferred by 150,000+ users; ranked #1–3 in the Apple App Store finance category.	

Product Designer (Contract)	
Payango — Berlin — worked remotely from Philadelphia, USA	Jan 2013 - Oct 2013
Designed user experiences for prepaid card, digital banking and payment products.	

Designer	
Andimol — Argentina, then remote from the USA	Aug 2011 - Nov 2012
Interaction design, UX and UI consultancy for Latin American firms including Guía de la Industria and 7screens. Continued remotely after relocating to the United States in January 2012.	

Design Analyst	
Globant — Argentina	Sep 2008 - Aug 2011
- Designed enterprise products and digital experiences for organisations including Google, JP Morgan, PwC, Coca-Cola, Telefónica and Travelocity, working within multidisciplinary product and engineering teams. - Alongside this, founded Bilitee (2010–2011), a social network for developers and designers.	

Early Career	
Synet Mexico, Datasygma & Independent — Argentina and Mexico	2005 - 2008
Motion design and content for Nokia HQ information screens (Sysnet, Mexico — worked remotely from Argentina); web design, CSS, HTML, CMS and client relationships (Datasygma); freelance and web design for small and medium businesses (independent).	

EDUCATION
Escuela Da Vinci — Multimedia & Web Design · 2002 - 2005
Universidad de Buenos Aires — Human Resources (Relaciones Laborales) · 1999 - 2002
SKILLS
Design Leadership · Product Strategy · Product Discovery · Open Banking · Payments · Platform & API-first Products · Developer Experience · Enterprise SaaS · Design Systems · Design Operations · User Research · Experimentation & A/B Testing · Accessibility · Stakeholder Management · HTML, CSS & JavaScript